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SHARATH KAMAL

Sharath Kamal bows out, a new generation rises

With Sharath Kamal's retirement, can Manav Thakkar lead Indian table tennis? A look at the **next generation** and the road ahead.

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For a better part of Achanta Sharath Kamal's two-decade-long career, everyone else who became India's top-ranked male table tennis player at any point had an invisible asterisk in front of their names.

Sharath's ability to perform well at major events and the magnitude of his achievements — 15 medals across the Asian and Commonwealth Games — made him the de facto India No. 1.

No Indian paddler has matched Sharath's longevity. Trained by his father, A. Srinivasa Rao, and uncle, A. Muralidhara Rao, he broke into the national team in the early 2000s, competing alongside veterans like S. Raman, Chetan Baboor, and Arup Basak. He then battled rivals from his own generation—Subhajit Saha, Soumyadeep Roy, Sourav Chakraborty, and Anthony Amalraj — many of whom have since turned to coaching.

Even as the next wave arrived — Soumyajit Ghosh, Sanil Shetty, G. Sathyan, and Harmeet Desai —

Sharath remained the benchmark. In 2018-19, he surpassed Kamlesh Mehta's record of eight National titles, defeating Sathyan, 10 years his junior, in the final. He repeated the feat in 2021-22, securing his 10th title — an achievement unlikely to be matched anytime soon.

The 6'1" powerhouse, who carried Indian table tennis on his broad shoulders, retired at 42 after a round-of-16 loss at the WTT Star Contender event in his hometown Chennai on March 29. His departure inevitably raised the question: Who after Sharath?

Sathyan seemed the obvious answer a while back. Ranked as high as 24 in the ITTF rankings in 2019 — India's best-ever for a male paddler — he followed in the footsteps of fellow Chennaite Sharath, collecting seven Commonwealth and Asian Games medals. But the expected "passing of the torch" never materialised. Sathyan, now outside the Top 100, watched as Sharath remained India's top player even in his fifth Olympic appearance in Paris last year.

A few hours after Sharath's farewell, a bespectacled, lean, 5'10" paddler staked his claim to be India's

next big hope. His name is Manav Thakkar.

Ranked 63rd, Manav Thakkar had struggled at the senior level, with WTT Contender quarterfinals in Nigeria and Argentina as his best results. In Chennai, he seemed headed for another exit at the same stage, trailing World No. 43 Lim Jong-hoon.

Then came a stunning turnaround — he won 20 of the next 21 points to seal a 3-2 victory, becoming the first Indian man to reach a WTT Star Contender semifinal. He also defeated World No. 35 Finn Luu.

Unlike Sharath's power-driven game, Thakkar thrives on counter-attacks. His Chennai performance highlighted newfound mental toughness. "In 2022-23, I lost many deciding-game matches. My mental coach, Gayatri Vartak, advised me to slow down, focus on serve and receive, and not overthink," he said. "Sometimes, if I felt nervous, I'd pause to adjust my shoelaces, just to refocus."

After his semifinal loss to unseeded Frenchman Thibault Poret, Thakkar was back at the practice tables with coaches Chris Pfeiffer and Massimo Costantini. "My touch was